apparently irrelevant to the protestors (as well as to four BJP chief ministers, who pre-emptively announced a ban on screening the yet-unreleased film in their states). When the film was eventually released on the orders of the Supreme Court, violent protests by hoodlums, including an attack on a school bus, successfully intimidated theatre owners, so that the film was not shown in several states even though they were free to screen it.

'Taking offence' is the name of the game these days; 'hurting the sentiments of a community' is the name of the crime. The old Hindu boasts of expansive tolerance are wearing thin. (But the film-maker should well have been warned by the experience of another film a decade ago, this time unconnected to any religious community. The threat of protests and possible prosecution had caused a Bollywood star and producer to retitle a film originally named *Billoo Barber* without the second word, because the hairdressers' community absurdly protested that the term 'barber' was an insult to their profession.)

It may not seem to matter very much what some lumpen elements think of a Bollywood film, or of Valentine's Day, for that matter. But it is precisely this kind of narrow-mindedness that also led to the notorious 'pulping' of Wendy Doniger's erudite study of Hinduism. If these intolerant bullies are allowed to get away with their lawless acts of intolerance and intimidation, we are allowing them to do violence to something profoundly vital to our survival as a civilisation.

Pluralist and democratic India must, by definition, tolerate plural expressions of its many identities. To allow the self-appointed arbiters of Bharatiya sanskriti to impose their hypocrisy and double standards on the rest of us is to permit them to define Indianness down until it ceases to be Indian.

But I am not optimistic about the prospects for any such development. My late father, Chandran Tharoor, used to tell me more than five decades ago that India is not just the world's largest democracy, it is also the world's largest hypocrisy. The wisdom and accuracy of his perception was again on display when my two attempts to introduce a Private Member's Bill to amend Section 377 of the Indian Penal Code (which